# FREEMASONRY'S STANDARDS AND VALUES

In a report adopted on 11th March 2015, the Board of General Purposes stated that:

> *"The Board is concerned at the apparent increase in the number of disciplinary cases coming before those Masonic authorities charged with the duty of dealing with such matters. Freemasonry is above all a moral organisation, founded on the principles of Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth – or, as it could more familiarly be put in the language of today, kindness; charity and generosity; and integrity and honesty. Those principles – if they are to mean anything – clearly require the maintenance of the highest standards of behaviour by Freemasons in both public and private life. Whilst it is doubtless the case that the standard of conduct among Freemasons remains generally very high, the Board considers it appropriate to reiterate this obvious truth."*
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> *"Not only is the conduct required of all Freemasons implicit in all that we do, but it has been set out expressly in writing on several occasions. For example, in June 1987 the Grand Lodge adopted the paragraph reprinted annually in Information for the Guidance of Members of the Craft under the heading "Freemasonry and Society", which concludes with the words, "The principles of the Craft make it clear to [the new Initiate] that his duty as a Freemason does not conflict with his duty as a citizen, but reinforces it." In September 1989, Rule 179 of the Book of Constitutions was amended to make explicit what had always been implicit: "As a citizen every Freemason has a duty not to engage in conduct which is contrary to the law of the land. As a Freemason he also has a duty not to engage in activity which may bring Freemasonry into disrepute." It cannot be too clearly stated that such duty does not extend only to matters regulated by the criminal courts but also covers enactments dealing, inter alia, with discrimination and health and safety, as well as those codes of conduct which cover matters such as disclosure of interests."*
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> *"The principles of Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth also carry with them the notion of tolerance. Whilst this, of course, principally speaks to relations with and respect for others, regrettably there are from time to time instances of one Brother pursuing a grievance against another Brother or group of Brethren in so single-minded a manner that, however well-founded some aspect of his grievance may originally have been, all sense of proportion has been lost and his actions have crossed the line between what is reasonable and what is not, so that they have become vexatious and wholly unreasonable. We are urged in our ritual to drop a tear of sympathy over the failings of a Brother. Those words emphatically do not require Freemasons to condone lapses in standards by their fellow Freemasons, but they do require them to be proportionate in their response to such lapses, so that a Brother who signally fails to exercise a due sense of proportion, in the absence of circumstances which might justify such conduct, may himself be guilty of a significant lapse from Masonic standards of behaviour."*